

so much to be celebrated when we are able to find our people both near and far.

But it's not without risk! Even more endless than the friends we can find online is the opportunity to spend. From influencers to scammers, all are vying for a piece of what we've got, and we need to be aware and in charge of our decisions.

Curating the content we engage with offers lots of protection for impulse spending. Choosing to follow the social media accounts that support your current life aspirations and provide the information and learning opportunities you're looking for will serve you better than allowing the algorithm to choose. Recognizing when posts are straight-up ads and when those ads are for products you don't need can keep social media a safe space rather than a spending trap.

This awareness and healthy dose of skepticism is also non-negotiable when it comes to protection from scams. With increasingly sophisticated AI tools, scams are becoming more complex and harder to detect. The misconception that only dumb people get scammed online is just not true. Scammers target smart people in vulnerable seasons of life with scams that are long-term and extremely psychologically manipulative. So, we have to know the signs early to prepare ourselves and protect our finances. Some key things to do and watch out for include:

Don't reply to "wrong number" text messages from unrecognized or blocked phone numbers.

Never download an investing app sent to you from someone who you don't trust for financial advice.

Beware of anyone rushing you to pick up the pace and make your relationship exclusive.

Scammers frequently pose as someone wanting to be romantically involved, but more often they're claiming to just want to be friends. They won't ask you for money; instead they'll show you the money they're making through investments and give you the link to "invest" if you want to. In reality, there are no investments. Other times scammers are posing as banking institutions or a subscription software you use or have used. In these instances, being sure to contact those businesses using your typical methods is advised. Finally, in the situations where scammers are posing as family members from different phone numbers, hang up and call that person directly. Better yet, have a code word with loved ones to confirm